different kinds of terrain. While the Ganga in the vicinity of Pataliputra is grand in its breadth and beauty, this is perhaps the only natural feature in its favour. The area is monotonously flat and fairly swampy on its edges, fringed on one side by marshes created by the Punpun river. Rajagriha, by contrast, was girdled by magnificent hills that gave it a naturally defensive character. Additionally, extensive cyclopean fortress-like walls were built across the hills, as also all kinds of structures ranging from monastic retreats to royal residences.[11] And yet, as Magadha expanded and jostled for territorial supremacy over states that extended along and beyond the left bank of the Ganga, it became increasingly clear that it was impractical for the political hub of an expansionist state to be located there. From the interior hilly terrain of Rajagriha, it would not have been possible to adequately protect the state's exposed long flank along the river.



Fig. 2.1: The hills of Rajagriha with a stupa in the foreground